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From stigma to mainstream: a multi-stakeholder thematic analysis of anime consumption and community-driven communication in Thai Generation Z

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ABSTRACT

This qualitative study explores the transformation of Japanese animation (anime) media consumption in Thailand, focusing on Generation Z. The research examines communication strategies within the anime ecosystem and related consumption behaviors through a multi-stakeholder lens, addressing gaps in understanding community-driven influence and identity construction. Semi-structured in-depth interviews were conducted with 23 participants across four stakeholder groups—event organizers, influencers, casual viewers, and niche community members—in Bangkok. Data were analyzed using reflexive thematic analysis. Four key findings emerge: (1) anime has undergone a social transformation from stigmatized activity to mainstream cultural practice; (2) a Trust-Network Model operates in which intimate word-of-mouth superseded algorithmic reach in driving consumption decisions; (3) fan communities and events function as ‘identity laboratories’ enabling safe self-exploration; and (4) dedicated fans wield significant economic power, challenging conventional ‘otaku’ stereotypes. Theoretically, the study advances cultural globalization theory through an ‘Organic Globalization’ framework, extends participatory culture theory by validating lurker participation along an engagement spectrum, and introduces an ‘Identity Laboratories’ framework highlighting the psychosocial developmental functions of media fandoms. These findings offer practical insights for content creators, marketers, and cultural industry stakeholders seeking authentic engagement with Generation Z.

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identity; race; gender; technology; digital; data justice; surveillance; visual culture; time; space; health; media; popular culture; consumer culture

1. Introduction

The consumption of Japanese animation, or anime, in Thailand has transformed dramatically over the past two decades. Once viewed as a marginalized subculture associated with social stigma, anime has now become a mainstream cultural phenomenon embraced across demographic segments (Otmazgin, 2007). This shift reflects both the broader influence of Japanese popular culture as soft power in Southeast Asia and the distinctive media consumption patterns of Generation Z – the first truly digital-native generation. The economic dimensions of this transformation are equally significant: Thailand now hosts a thriving anime industry characterized by proliferating events, streaming platforms, licensed merchandise and diverse fan communities (Agyeiwaah et al., 2019; Hu & Cheong, 2021; Tirocchi, 2023).

Despite growing academic interest in Japanese pop culture globalization (Iwabuchi, 2002, 2015; Otmazgin, 2007, 2012) and Generation Z consumer behavior (Singer et al., 2023; Wilska et al., 2023), four significant scholarly gaps persist.

First, most existing studies adopt a narrow consumer viewpoint, excluding the multi-stakeholder perspectives – event organizers, content creators, influencers that are essential for understanding the media ecosystem holistically (Tung et al., 2017). Second, limited research examines the specific mechanisms through which

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communication strategies function within Generation Z's complex digital media environment, particularly in Southeast Asian contexts where platform adoption and cultural dynamics differ from Western settings.

Third, while fan community formation has received attention, insufficient work explores how identity construction within these communities interacts with and actively drives consumption behaviors. Fourth, economic analyses of fan engagement frequently rely on stereotypical assumptions about 'otaku' spending patterns, lacking a nuanced examination of the sophisticated, value-driven consumption that characterizes dedicated fan segments.

This study aims to address these gaps by investigating, from an integrated multi-stakeholder perspective, the communication strategies and consumption behaviors shaping Japanese animation media engagement among Generation Z in Thailand. The research is guided by four interrelated questions:

1. What communication strategies effectively reach and influence anime consumption behaviors among Thai Generation Z?
2. What factors shape Generation Z's decision-making processes regarding anime consumption, and how do these decisions unfold?
3. How do fan community formation and engagement contribute to both consumption behaviors and identity construction?
4. What challenges and opportunities exist for engaging Generation Z with Japanese animation media within the Thai cultural context?

This article proceeds as follows. Following this introduction, the Literature Review synthesizes existing work on cultural globalization, Generation Z media consumption and fan studies. The Methodology section details the qualitative, multi-stakeholder approach using semi-structured interviews and reflexive thematic analysis. The Results section presents four key themes emerging from the data. The Discussion interprets these findings, linking them to theoretical frameworks and articulating the study's contributions. Finally, the Conclusion summarizes the key insights, outlines theoretical and practical implications and suggests directions for future research.

2. Literature review

This review synthesizes scholarship across three interconnected domains to position this study: the globalization of Japanese popular culture, the distinctive media ecology of Generation Z, and the evolving nature of fan communities and participatory culture. A critical analysis reveals that while these fields are rich, their intersection – particularly in non-Western contexts like Thailand, remains underexplored, often relying on consumer-centric views and outdated assumptions about fan economics.

2.1. Cultural globalization and 'cool Japan': from policy to organic flow

The global ascent of anime is frequently analyzed through the lens of Japan's 'soft power' or 'Cool Japan' strategy, a state-sponsored initiative to enhance international influence through cultural exports (Iwabuchi, 2002, 2015; McGray, 2002). However, scholars like Otmazgin (2007, 2012) convincingly argue that its success in Southeast Asia stems less from top-down policy and more from commercial networks and grassroots fan communities. This points to a process of organic globalization, where cultural dissemination is multidirectional and driven by appropriation rather than imposition (Appadurai, 1996). Recent work emphasizes glocalization (Roudometof, 2016) and cultural hybridity (Kraidy, 2002), where global products are actively localized. Fang (2023) call for intra-Asian cultural flow perspectives is crucial, challenging Western-centric models and urging attention to regional reception.

In the Thai context specifically, empirical research has begun documenting how Japanese popular culture, including anime, integrates into youth identity formation. Phornprapha and Podsatiangool (2019) found that Thai youth actively appropriate Japanese pop culture elements to construct distinctive identities that blend local and global influences. Similarly, other researchers demonstrated that Thai anime fans engage in complex meaning-making practices, reinterpreting Japanese cultural content through local lenses. These studies confirm that anime consumption in Thailand is not passive reception but active cultural negotiation (Smutradontri & Gadavanij, 2020).

Yet a significant gap remains in understanding the digital mechanisms of this organic, community-driven spread and its direct link to consumption behaviors among the newest generation of fans.

2.2. Generation Z: digital natives, sceptical consumers and value-seekers

Generation Z (born 1997–2012) are not merely ‘digital natives’ (Prensky, 2001) but exhibit nuanced media behaviors that defy simplistic marketing. Critical synthesis reveals a cohort defined by contradiction: they are fluent across platforms (Hu & Cheong, 2021) yet their wellbeing is tied more to quality of engagement than quantity (Godard & Holtzman, 2023); they gravitate to short-form content (McCashin & Murphy, 2023) but are capable of deep, sustained engagement with meaningful material; and they are inundated with influencer marketing yet are profoundly sceptical of inauthenticity (Pradhan et al., 2023; Singer et al., 2023). This generation seeks authenticity and value-alignment (Tirocchi, 2023; Wilska et al., 2023), making traditional advertising ineffective. Crucially, their consumption is socially embedded – research confirms the power of electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) and peer influence (Babić Rosario et al., 2016; Ngo et al., 2024; Otterbring, 2021). However, most studies on Gen Z media consumption are platform or brand-focused, failing to examine how these traits manifest within a specific, all-encompassing cultural fandom like anime, where community and identity are paramount.

2.3. Fan communities: beyond participation toward identity and economic agency

Fan studies, anchored by Jenkins (2006, 2013) participatory culture paradigm, have evolved into a mature interdisciplinary field that moves beyond viewing fans as passive consumers. However, recent critiques highlight evolving challenges like ‘participatory fatigue’ (Porlezza, 2019) and ‘fanspiracies’ (Driessen et al., 2024), while digital platforms reshape engagement (James, 2025; Jenkins & Jie, 2024). For anime fandoms specifically, research reveals their role as spaces for exploring gender and sexuality (Eng, 2012; Galbraith, 2019). A critical debate centers on defining ‘fan’ engagement, with emerging work challenging the active/passive binary. Studies on the ‘lurker phenomenon’ (Sun et al., 2014) and ‘passive yet devoted’ fans (Zheng, 2025) argue for a spectrum of participation, a notion supported by findings that passive use can maintain social connection (Godard & Holtzman, 2023). Furthermore, the economic dimension of fandom is often stereotyped. Scholarship now challenges the ‘otaku’ cliché, revealing sophisticated, high-disposable-income consumers with significant ‘kidult’ spending power (Tung et al., 2017).

Research within Thailand has begun illuminating these dynamics. Phornprapha and Podsatiangool (2019) provided early evidence that Thai anime fandoms function as spaces for identity experimentation, particularly among youth navigating the tensions between traditional Thai values and global popular culture. More recently, Smutradontri and Gadavanij (2020) demonstrated through analysis of Thai fans’ Twitter engagement that fandom participation enables identity construction through both content consumption and social interaction with fellow fans.

However, these valuable studies, while establishing the importance of fandom for Thai youth, are limited by their focus on single platforms (Twitter) and their reliance on consumer-only perspectives. What remains absent is a multi-stakeholder, economically nuanced analysis of the entire anime media ecosystem that captures the perspectives of event organizers, content creators and diverse fan segments simultaneously.

2.4. Synthesized gap and this study’s positioning

This critical review identifies a convergent gap: a lack of integrated, contemporary research that examines the organic, community-driven communication strategies within a specific fandom, their interplay with Generation Z’s values-driven, peer-influenced consumption, and the identity work and economic sophistication of fans, all within a non-Western context. While valuable regional studies have established that Thai youth engage deeply with anime and use fandom for identity work (Phornprapha & Podsatiangool, 2019; Smutradontri & Gadavanij, 2020), these investigations have necessarily focused on specific platforms or consumer perspectives. They have not yet captured the full ecosystem of stakeholders, including event organizers, content creators and diverse fan segments that shape contemporary anime consumption.

Existing literature, both globally and regionally, tends to isolate the elements of cultural flow, generational behavior, and fan participation rather than examining their interconnection. This study positions itself directly within and beyond these debates. Building on foundational regional insights, it employs a multi-stakeholder qualitative approach to investigate the Thai anime ecosystem holistically, thereby offering both empirical depth and theoretical contributions grounded in the Southeast Asian context.

This study seeks to advance theories of cultural globalization by exploring ‘organic’ digital flows, to refine understanding of Gen Z consumption within a passionate interest domain, and to contribute to fan studies by validating diverse participation modes and analyzing nuanced economic behaviors. The conceptual framework (Figure 1) integrates these elements, proposing that communication strategies, filtered through Gen Z characteristics and community dynamics, shape consumption outcomes within a specific cultural and economic context.

3. Methodology

3.1. Research design and rationale

This study employs a qualitative research design using semi-structured in-depth interviews as the primary data collection method. A qualitative approach was selected as the research questions seek to understand the complex, socially constructed experiences, perspectives and meanings that multiple stakeholders assign to anime consumption, inquiries inaccessible through quantitative methods alone (Braun & Clarke, 2019). The multi-stakeholder perspective was adopted to capture the holistic ecosystem of anime media in Thailand, recognizing that event organizers, influencers, casual viewers and niche

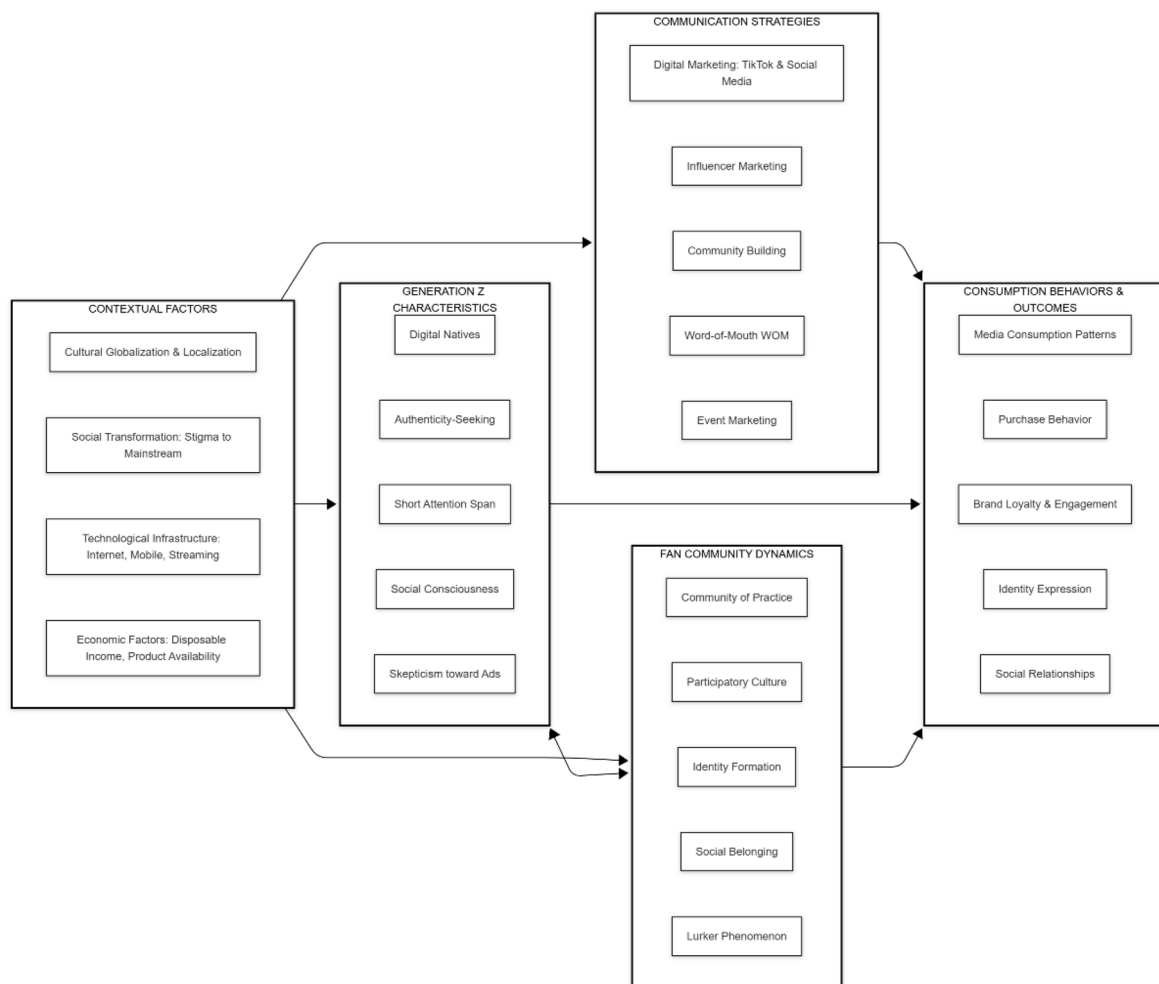


Figure 1. Conceptual framework.

community members each possess distinct, valuable insights that collectively provide a comprehensive understanding of communication strategies and consumption behaviors.

3.2. Participant selection and recruitment

Purposive sampling was used to select participants with direct knowledge and varied involvement in the Thai anime ecosystem. A total of 23 participants were recruited across four stakeholder groups (see [Table 1](#)). Participants ranged in age from 19 to 31 years, with variations across stakeholder groups: event organizers and entrepreneurs (ages 26–31), influencers and content creators (ages 23–26), casual viewers (ages 20–24) and niche community members (ages 19–25). This age distribution ensured representation across the Generation Z spectrum (born 1997–2012) while also capturing perspectives from slightly older stakeholders (event organizers) whose professional experience provided valuable industry insights.

Recruitment employed a multi-pronged strategy: (1) leveraging personal networks and industry contacts for initial access; (2) employing snowball sampling where initial participants recommended peers; (3) posting announcements in targeted online spaces (e.g. anime-focused Facebook groups, Discord servers); and (4) direct, in-person recruitment at anime events in Bangkok. Recruitment continued until thematic saturation was reached to the point where subsequent interviews yielded no significant new insights, which occurred after approximately 20 interviews. Three additional interviews were conducted to ensure representation across all planned stakeholder groups.

3.3. Data collection procedures

Data collection occurred between March and April 2025. Interviews were conducted in locations convenient to participants: public coffee shops ($n=15$), via online video calls ($n=5$) and at event venues ($n=3$). A semi-structured interview guide was developed with core questions tailored to each stakeholder group (see [Appendix A](#) for a sample interview guide), exploring: (1) roles and communication strategies; (2) community engagement; (3) influences on consumption; and (4) identity and social dynamics. Each interview began with a reiteration of the study's purpose and obtaining informed consent for audio recording. Interviews lasted 35–75 min (average: 52 min). The researcher adopted a flexible, conversational style, using probes to elicit deeper responses while avoiding leading questions. All interviews were transcribed verbatim within 48 h.

3.4. Data analysis

The data were analyzed using reflexive thematic analysis following Braun and Clarke (2019, 2023) six-phase approach, chosen for its flexibility and suitability for identifying patterns of meaning across a complex dataset.

- Phase 1 (Familiarization): Transcripts were read repeatedly while listening to audio recordings.
- Phase 2 (Coding): Both inductive (data-driven) and deductive (theory-informed) codes were generated. Approximately 187 initial codes were organized using Microsoft Excel (see [Appendix B](#) for a sample codebook).
- Phase 3 (Theme Generation): Codes were clustered into potential themes and sub-themes, visualized through thematic maps.

Table 1. Participant demographics and characteristics ($N=23$, age range 19–31).

Group	Code	n	Characteristics	Selection criteria	Age range	Gender
A	A1–A5	5	Event Organizers/ Entrepreneurs	Event experience ≥ 2 years; Event attendance ≥ 500 people; Focus on Japanese culture	26–31	3 M, 2 F
B	B1–B4	4	Influencers/Voice Actors/ Content Creators	Followers $\geq 10,000$ on any platform; Regular anime content creation; Active community engagement	23–26	2 M, 2 F
C	C1–C7	7	Casual Viewers	Age 18–25 (Gen Z); Regular anime viewing (≥ 1 series/month); Not heavily involved in communities	20–24	4 M, 3 F
D	D1–D7	7	Niche Community Members (including Fujoshi)	Age 18–25; Deep community involvement; Participation in specific subcultures	19–25	1 M, 6 F

- Phase 4 (Theme Review): Themes were checked against the coded data and the entire dataset for coherence and distinctiveness.
- Phase 5 (Theme Definition/Naming): Clear definitions and concise names were developed for each theme.
- Phase 6 (Report Production): The analysis was woven into a narrative, supported by vivid, anonymized participant extracts.

3.5. Ensuring trustworthiness and ethical rigor

To ensure the study's credibility, we employed prolonged engagement with the field, triangulation of perspectives across stakeholder groups, member checking (where transcripts were returned to 7 participants for verification), and peer debriefing with academic colleagues. Ethical approval was granted by the relevant ethics committee at Chulalongkorn University (COA No. 103/68). All participants provided written informed consent. Confidentiality was maintained through pseudonymization (using codes A1–D7), and data were stored securely on password-protected devices.

3.6. Researcher positionality, reflexivity and limitations

Researcher positionality: The primary researcher is a member of the Thai academic community with an interest in media studies and youth culture. While not a core member of anime fan communities, this position allowed for both cultural familiarity and a degree of analytical distance. We actively reflected on how our positions might influence question framing and interpretation, using memoing during analysis to bracket assumptions.

Reflexivity: Throughout the research, we engaged in reflexive practice by maintaining an audit trail of analytical decisions, discussing emerging interpretations in research meetings and consciously seeking disconfirming evidence within the data to challenge initial themes.

Methodological limitations: While providing rich, contextual insights, this study has limitations. The sample, though diverse, is concentrated in Bangkok and may not represent experiences in rural Thailand. The qualitative design limits generalizability, though its purpose is analytical generalization rather than statistical representation. The reliance on self-reported interview data may be subject to social desirability bias. Finally, the single-method approach could be complemented in future research by ethnographic observation or quantitative surveys to provide additional layers of evidence.

4. Results

Analysis of the interview data revealed four central themes regarding the Thai anime ecosystem. Each theme is presented below with its constituent sub-themes and supported by direct evidence from participant accounts.

4.1. Theme 1: the social transformation of anime consumption from stigma to mainstream

This theme captures the profound shift in how anime consumption is perceived socially in Thailand, particularly among Generation Z.

4.1.1. From stigmatized to socially expected

Participants consistently described a reversal in social attitudes. Where anime was once seen as deviant, it is now the norm. *'In the past, anime viewers were considered weird. Now, whoever doesn't watch seems strange'* (A2, Event Organizer). A casual viewer echoed this: *'Previously, watching anime meant you were strange or childish. Now, not knowing popular anime excludes you from conversations with friends'* (C3).

4.1.2. Integration into daily routines and language

For many participants, anime consumption has become habitual. *'Watching anime before bed is like brushing teeth—it's just part of my routine now'* (D4, Niche Community Member). This normalization extends to language, with Japanese terms like *'yatta'* (hooray) or *'maku'* (to lose) being naturalized in everyday Thai youth conversation.

4.1.3. Anime as a resource for identity

Participants reported using anime as a tool for self-understanding and expression. *'Anime helped me understand myself better. Through characters and stories, I explored aspects of identity I couldn't express openly in real life'* (D6, Fujoshi). An influencer noted, *'For Gen Z, anime isn't just media consumption—it's identity expression. What anime you watch, what characters you like... these communicate who you are'* (B3).

4.2. Theme 2: the disconnect between algorithmic reach and trust-based influence in communication

This theme details the complex landscape of how Generation Z discovers and decides to consume anime, highlighting a key gap between awareness and action.

4.2.1. TikTok as the dominant discovery platform, not decision driver

Twenty of 23 participants cited TikTok as a primary source for discovering new anime. *'TikTok's algorithm is incredibly effective. Short clips with anime scenes go viral, creating curiosity'* (A1, Event Organizer). However, this rarely translated directly to viewing decisions. *'I see lots of anime on TikTok, but that doesn't mean I'll watch them. TikTok makes me aware, but my decision to actually watch depends on other factors'* (C5, Casual Viewer).

4.2.2. Intimate Word-of-Mouth as the primary influence

Despite TikTok's reach, personal recommendations from close friends were cited as the most trusted and influential factor by 21 of 23 participants. *'I see hundreds of recommendations online, but I only seriously consider watching if a close friend recommends it'* (D3, Niche Community Member). (D3, Niche Community Member).

4.2.3. The prevalent 'lurker' mode of community participation

Participants described most community members as passive observers. *'Most people in anime communities are silent observers. They read, view, and follow, but never post or comment. We call them lurkers'* (B1, Content Creator). A self-identified lurker explained, *'I read everything in the community and feel connected, but I rarely post. I'm definitely part of the community—I just participate differently'* (D5).

4.2.4. Nuanced views on influencer marketing

Participants expressed scepticism toward large-scale influencers perceived as inauthentic. *'Big influencers who review everything don't feel authentic. They promote whatever pays them'* (C4). Conversely, niche micro-influencers with specific expertise were trusted. *'I follow specific creators who focus on genres I like. They're real fans, not just promoters'* (D2).

4.3. Theme 3: fan communities and events as spaces for identity exploration and belonging

This theme outlines the roles communities and events play that extend beyond entertainment.

4.3.1. Events as platforms for identity experimentation

Anime events, especially cosplay, were described as safe spaces for trying on different identities. *'At anime events, I dress as characters representing aspects of myself, I can't express in daily life. It's like safely trying on different identities'* (D7).

4.3.2. Communities as sources of belonging and understanding

For many, these spaces provided primary social networks. *'My closest friends are from the anime community. We understand each other in ways my school friends don't'* (C6). This was especially salient for those feeling marginalized. *'In regular society, I felt weird for liking Boys' Love content. In the fujoshi community, it's normal. I found people like me'* (D1).

4.3.3. Pressures and negative aspects: beauty standards and social obligation

Participants also reported pressures. *'There's unspoken pressure to be attractive when cosplaying. I've seen friends stop because they felt they weren't pretty enough'* (D4). Other pressures included expectations to purchase merchandise, possess encyclopedic knowledge, or contribute actively to communities.

4.4. Theme 4: the economic sophistication and purchasing power of dedicated fans

This theme challenges economic stereotypes about anime fans, revealing strategic and significant consumption.

4.4.1. High and strategic spending of dedicated segments

Contrary to the 'impoverished otaku' stereotype, dedicated fans reported substantial, planned spending. *'The otaku segment has high purchasing power. They pay premium prices for quality merchandise, especially limited editions'* (A1). A community member detailed, *'I budget specifically for anime-related purchases. Last year, I spent over 50,000 baht on merchandise, events, and subscriptions'* (D6).

4.4.2. Success of brand collaboration products

Collaborations between anime franchises and other brands were highlighted as particularly effective. *'When my favourite anime collaborates with brands I like, it's perfect—functional products featuring characters I love'* (C7).

4.4.3. Generational differences in consumption patterns

Participants delineated clear differences between Generation Z and older fans (Millennials/Gen X). Gen Z was described as favoring experiences, value-driven consumption and platforms like TikTok and Discord. Older generations were seen as prioritizing complete collections, brand loyalty and using platforms like Facebook.

5. Discussion

This study set out to investigate the communication strategies and consumption behaviors surrounding Japanese animation media among Generation Z in Thailand through a multi-stakeholder lens. The findings reveal a sophisticated ecosystem where social perception, community dynamics and economic behavior have undergone significant transformation. This discussion interprets these findings by directly engaging with the literature reviewed earlier, showing how they extend, challenge, or refine existing theories and explicitly foregrounding the study's original scholarly contributions.

5.1. Engaging with the literature: interpretation of key findings

5.1.1. Organic globalization and the digital reversal of stigma

The documented social transformation of anime from a stigmatized to a mainstream activity (Theme 1) extends theories of cultural globalization (Appadurai, 1996; Iwabuchi, 2002). It provides empirical support for Otmazgin's (2007) argument about grassroots adoption over top-down policy, but in a digital-native context. The speed and scale of this shift, driven by algorithmic platforms like TikTok and organic peer networks, challenge slower, institution-centered models of cultural flow.

This phenomenon, which we term 'organic globalization,' requires explicit differentiation from the established concept of glocalization. Glocalization, as theorized by Roudometof (2016) and Kraidy (2002), primarily describes how global cultural products are adapted and reinterpreted by local consumers,

a process of downward appropriation where global meets local. Organic globalization, by contrast, describes a distinct process of outward and peer-to-peer cultural transmission. It is not primarily about how Thai youth reinterpret Japanese anime (though this occurs), but about how they actively propagate, normalize and legitimize anime consumption within their social worlds through digital networks.

Three key features distinguish organic globalization from glocalization. First, **driver**: while glocalization emphasizes how local audiences adapt global content, organic globalization foregrounds how consumers themselves become agents of cultural propagation, actively spreading content through peer networks. Second, **speed and scale**: organic globalization operates at viral velocity, accelerated by algorithmic platforms like TikTok that enable rapid, 大规模 normalization impossible in pre-digital glocalization processes. Third, **directionality**: glocalization assumes a global-to-local flow that is then adapted; organic globalization captures multidirectional flows where cultural legitimacy emerges horizontally through peer validation rather than vertically through institutional or corporate endorsement.

In the Thai context, anime's destigmatization occurred not because Japanese cultural institutions or Thai media companies successfully localized the product, but because Generation Z consumers themselves, through TikTok shares, Discord conversations and intimate word-of-mouth, collectively redefined anime as mainstream. This represents organic globalization: a process where digital infrastructure accelerates grassroots, peer-to-peer cultural transmission, leading to rapid social normalization without formal institutional promotion. The framework thus refines and extends glocalization theory by specifying the digital, community-driven mechanisms through which contemporary cultural flows operate.

5.1.2. The trust-network model: challenging assumptions of algorithmic influence

Theme 2's core finding as indicated in Figure 2 that intimate word-of-mouth trumps algorithmic reach in driving consumption directly engages with and extends literature on eWOM (Babić Rosario et al., 2016; Ngo et al., 2024) and Gen Z's authenticity-seeking (Pradhan et al., 2023; Singer et al., 2023). While research

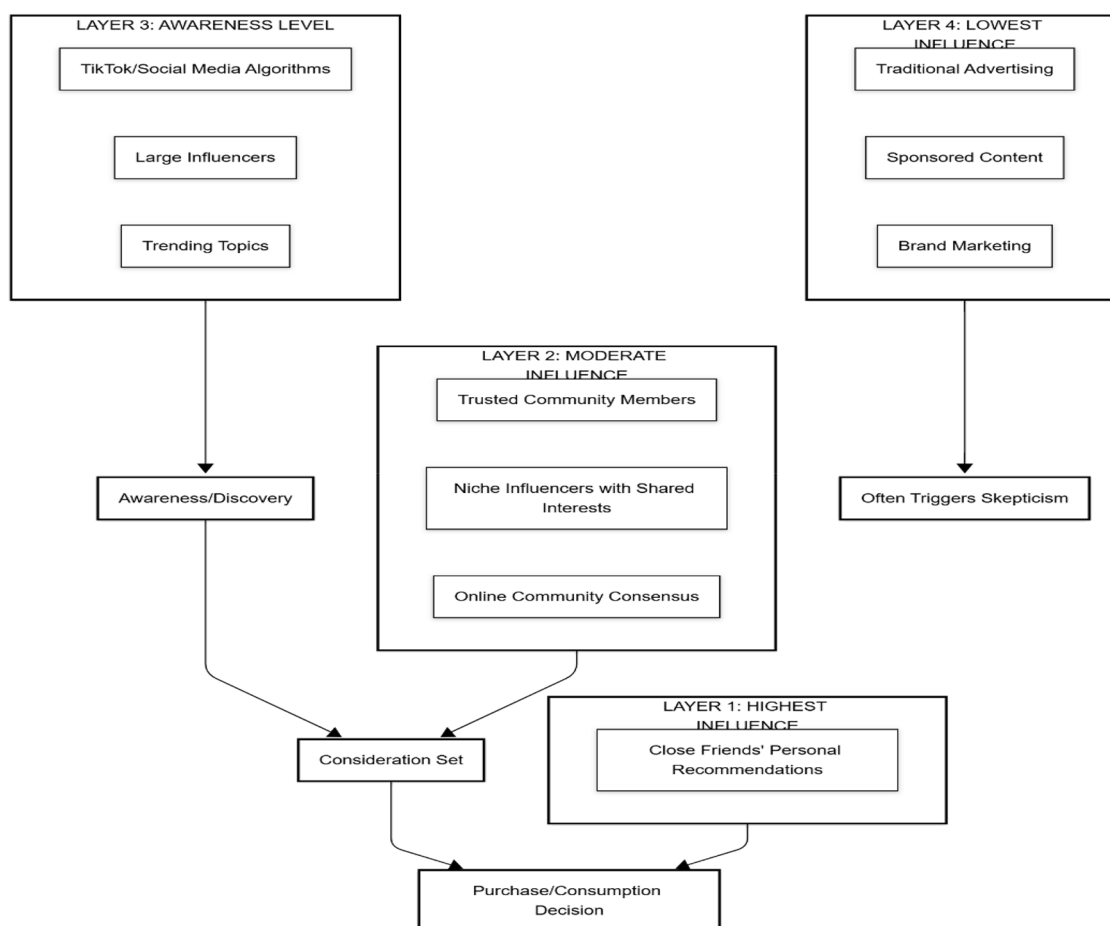


Figure 2. Trust-network model of communication influence.

acknowledges peer influence (Otterbring, 2021), our findings introduce a layered 'Trust-Network Model'. This model clarifies that while platforms like TikTok (Kang & Lou, 2022) excel at creating awareness in an outer layer of reach, conversion happens in an inner layer governed by intimacy and trust. This challenges marketing over-reliance on reach metrics and refines our understanding of digital communication effectiveness.

5.1.3. Identity laboratories: extending participatory culture theory

The finding that communities and events serve as spaces for identity exploration and belonging (Theme 3) significantly extends Jenkins (2006, 2013) participatory culture paradigm. While Jenkins focused on textual production and collective intelligence, our findings highlight the *psychosocial and developmental functions* of these spaces, conceptualizing them as identity laboratories. This aligns with and expands work on fandom and identity (Smutradontri & Gadavani, 2020), providing a framework that explains *why* participation matters for Gen Z: it facilitates safe experimentation, peer validation and self-discovery during a key life stage.

5.1.4. Reconceptualizing participation and challenging economic stereotypes

The prevalence of lurkers (Theme 2.3) challenges the active/passive binary in fan studies. Our data support and extend recent work validating lurking as legitimate participation (Sun et al., 2014; Zheng, 2025), proposing a spectrum of fan engagement. Furthermore, Theme 4 directly challenges outdated 'otaku' stereotypes by providing evidence of sophisticated, value-driven economic agency. This refines the economic understanding of fan consumption from impulsive to strategic, aligning with findings on the 'kidult' market (Tung et al., 2017) but specifying its Gen Z iteration.

5.2. Foregrounding theoretical contribution

This study's primary scholarly contribution is the development and integration of three mid-range theoretical frameworks that arise from the intersection of our empirical findings and existing literature:

1. **The organic globalization framework:** Explains rapid, digital-era cultural normalization *via* grassroots peer networks, advancing beyond both state-centric soft power models and established globalization theory. While globalization focuses on how global products are adapted locally, organic globalization captures how consumers themselves become agents of cultural propagation, actively spreading and legitimizing content through digital networks at viral speed and scale. This framework specifies the community-driven mechanisms, algorithmic amplification, peer validation and horizontal transmission that distinguish contemporary cultural flows from earlier models of globalization.
2. **The trust-network model of digital communication:** Clarifies the layered structure of influence in saturated media environments, where trust networks mediate between algorithmic awareness and behavioral conversion.
3. **The identity laboratories framework:** Expands participatory culture theory by foregrounding the identity-development function of fan communities, offering a new lens for understanding youth engagement with media fandoms.

Collectively, these frameworks provide a novel, integrated way to analyze contemporary transcultural fandom, emphasizing the interplay between digital platforms, community-based trust, identity formation and sophisticated consumption.

This study's findings extend cultural globalization theories by revealing how digital-era cultural transmission operates through grassroots networks rather than institutional channels. The rapid social transformation documented – from anime stigmatization to mainstream acceptance – occurred through organic peer-to-peer transmission rather than government-led cultural diplomacy or corporate marketing campaigns (Iwabuchi, 2002, 2015; Otmazgin, 2007).

This represents what we term 'organic globalization': cultural spread through authentic community adoption, algorithmic amplification on digital platforms, trust-network transmission and local reinterpretation. This process differs fundamentally from traditional globalization models, operating at unprecedented speed and scale through digital infrastructure while maintaining grassroots authenticity (Fang, 2023; Roudometof, 2016).

5.3. Practical contributions

For **Marketers**: Shift focus from reach metrics to community cultivation; invest in authentic relationships rather than paid advertising; recognize that awareness and conversion require different strategies; acknowledge lurkers as valuable segments deserving tailored approaches.

For **Event organizers**: Design spaces consciously supporting safe identity exploration; create inclusive environments recognizing diverse participation modes; address beauty standards and social pressures proactively; balance commercial objectives with community support functions.

For **Content creators**: Prioritize authenticity and genuine passion over commercial optimization; engage deeply with niche communities rather than pursuing mass appeal; maintain transparency about sponsorships and commercial relationships; create content that people want to share naturally.

For **Policymakers**: Support creative industries recognizing economic potential; promote healthy community environments addressing social pressures; encourage ethical business practices in merchandising and events; recognize media's role in youth identity development.

5.4. Limitations

Sample limitations: While appropriate for qualitative research, 23 participants may not represent all Thai Gen Z anime consumers, particularly those in rural areas, from diverse socioeconomic backgrounds or with limited internet access.

Temporal limitations: Two-month data collection cannot capture dynamic changes or long-term trends in this rapidly evolving landscape.

Geographic concentration: Focus on Bangkok and the vicinity may not reflect experiences in other Thai regions with different cultural contexts and media access.

Self-selection bias: Voluntary participants likely represent more engaged fans than the general population, potentially excluding casual consumers or those with negative experiences.

Lack of corporate perspectives: Missing viewpoints from large importers, publishers and high-level policymakers who might offer different strategic insights.

Single-method limitation: Single interviews may not capture full complexity; ethnographic observation could provide additional depth.

6. Conclusion

This qualitative study has explored the sophisticated ecosystem of Japanese animation media consumption among Generation Z in Thailand through a multi-stakeholder lens. Moving beyond a simple analysis of preferences, it reveals how this fandom operates as a site of significant social transformation, community-driven communication, identity development and sophisticated economic activity.

The study advances three interrelated theoretical frameworks Organic Globalization, the Trust-Network Model and Identity Laboratories – that collectively explain how digital-era cultural transmission operates through grassroots networks, how trust mediates between algorithmic awareness and consumption decisions, and how fan communities serve as spaces for psychosocial development. These frameworks extend existing scholarship on cultural globalization, Gen Z media behavior, and participatory culture by specifying the community-driven mechanisms through which contemporary fandom operates.

For industry practitioners and cultural institutions, the findings emphasize that sustainable engagement with Generation Z requires cultivating authentic communities rather than pursuing broad advertising reach. Recognizing diverse participation modes, including 'lurkers' and designing inclusive spaces that support identity exploration are essential strategies. Policymakers should note the significant economic potential of culturally rooted fan markets while supporting ethical practices and healthy community environments.

The study's limitations point to clear avenues for future research. Subsequent work should: (1) employ mixed-methods or longitudinal designs to capture the dynamic evolution of this ecosystem; (2) expand the geographical scope beyond Bangkok to explore regional and rural variations in Thailand; (3) investigate the perspectives of corporate stakeholders (e.g. distributors and publishers) for a complete industry view; and (4) apply and test the proposed frameworks in other cultural fandoms or national contexts to assess their broader applicability.

In summary, this research demonstrates that for Generation Z in Thailand, anime consumption transcends entertainment. It is a multifaceted phenomenon through which social norms are reshaped, identity is negotiated and economic value is generated within digitally mediated communities of trust. Understanding these complex dynamics is essential for scholars and practitioners aiming to meaningfully engage with the digital-native generation shaping the future of global cultural consumption.

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Authors' contribution

CRedit: **Chayanon Krongbooncho**: Conceptualization, Data curation, Formal analysis, Software, Validation, Writing – original draft; **Smith Boonchutima**: Investigation, Supervision, Validation, Visualization; **Ibtesam Mazahir**: Data curation, Investigation, Methodology, Validation, Writing – review & editing.

Ethical approval statement

To ensure the privacy and confidentiality of the participants, no personally identifiable information was collected during the data collection. The data were anonymized and stored securely, with access restricted to the researchers directly involved in the study. The study adhered to the ethical guidelines and principles set forth by Chulalongkorn University and the Faculty of Communication Arts, ensuring the protection of participant privacy and confidentiality throughout the research process as per the Declaration of Helsinki. The study was approved by the Research Ethics Review Committee for Research Involving Human Subjects: The Second Allied Academic Group in Social Sciences, Humanities and Fine and Allied Arts, Bangkok, Thailand, under the COA No. 103/68 dated 13 March, 2025.

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Data availability statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available on request from the corresponding author.

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Appendix A: Interview guide (Sample – Group C: Casual viewers)

Section 1: Anime consumption behaviors

1. How did you first become interested in anime?
2. How frequently do you watch anime? Which platforms do you use?
3. How do you decide which anime to watch?
4. What factors make you continue watching a series or stop?

Section 2: Community and social aspects

1. Do you discuss anime with friends or online? How?
2. Have you attended any anime-related events?
3. Do you consider yourself part of the anime fan community? Why or why not?

Section 3: Communication and influence

1. Where do you typically discover new anime?
2. How much do recommendations from friends *versus* online influencers influence your choices?
3. What makes you trust a recommendation source?
4. How do you feel about anime-related advertising or sponsored content?

Section 4: Identity and personal meaning

1. What role does anime play in your life?
2. Has anime influenced your identity or how you see yourself?
3. Do you own any anime merchandise? What motivates those purchases?

Appendix B: Codebook (sample)

Code	Definition	Example quote	Theme
Social_Stigma_Past	References to negative social perceptions of anime in the past	'เมื่อก่อนใครดูการ์ตูนถือว่าแปลก'	Theme 1
Mainstream_Now	Descriptions of anime as currently mainstream	'เดี๋ยวนี้ใครไม่ดูอนิเมะคือดูเวท'	Theme 1
Friend_Recommend	Friend recommendations influencing decisions	'ถ้าเพื่อนสนิทแนะนำจะดูแน่'	Theme 2
TikTok_Discovery	Using TikTok to discover anime	'เห็นในTikTokเยอะมาก'	Theme 2
Identity_Exploration	Using anime for identity exploration	'อนิเมะช่วยให้เข้าใจตัวเองมากขึ้น'	Theme 3